Crime and punishment

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Crime and punishment: does prison work? (202 words)

Every society must decide what to do with those who break its laws. Traditionally the answer has been punishment: a **fine** for minor wrongdoing, a prison **sentence** for serious crime. The assumption is that harsh penalties act as a **deterrent** and protect the **victim** and the public. The evidence is, however, mixed. Many **offender**s **reoffend** soon after release, and **prison overcrowding** makes it harder to teach skills or change attitudes.

For that reason many experts favour **rehabilitation**. They argue that a young **juvenile** offender, in particular, needs education and a chance to **turn over a new leaf**, and that **community service** repays harm more usefully than a cell. Crimes also change. Cases of online **fraud** are growing, while **burglary** and **vandalism** have fallen in cities with good **surveillance camera** coverage. A **witness** may now be a video, and a **conviction** can depend on digital evidence.

Strong **law enforcement** helps to **prevent** crime, but experts insist that the most effective strategies tackle its causes: poverty, poor schooling and lack of opportunity. The debate over **capital punishment** shows how far societies disagree about **justice** itself. In the end, a fair system must **strike a balance between** protecting the public and respecting the rights of the accused.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
turn over a new leaf	begin a better life
strike a balance between	find a fair middle point between

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
offender	n	a person who commits a crime	*Young offenders need education, not just prison.*
deterrent	n	something that stops people doing wrong	*Harsh sentences may act as a deterrent.*
rehabilitation	n	helping a criminal to return to normal life	*Rehabilitation reduces repeat crime.*
sentence	n	the punishment given by a court	*He received a five-year sentence.*
fine	n	money paid as a punishment	*The company paid a heavy fine.*

community service	n	unpaid work done as punishment	*Community service helps the offender give back.*
reoffend	v	to commit another crime	*Many prisoners reoffend after release.*
burglary	n	breaking into a building to steal	*Burglary rates fell last year.*
law enforcement	n	the work of police and courts	*Law enforcement needs more resources.*
witness	n	a person who sees a crime	*The witness described the thief.*
conviction	n	a court decision that someone is guilty	*His conviction was widely reported.*
juvenile	adj	connected with young people	*Juvenile crime is often linked to poverty.*
capital punishment	n	the death penalty	*Capital punishment is banned in many countries.*
prison overcrowding	n	too many prisoners for the space	*Prison overcrowding makes rehabilitation harder.*
fraud	n	getting money by lying	*Online fraud costs billions each year.*
vandalism	n	damaging property on purpose	*Vandalism spoils public parks.*
surveillance camera	n	a camera used to watch public places	*Surveillance cameras reduced street crime.*
prevent	v	to stop something from happening	*Education can prevent crime.*
justice	n	fair treatment under the law	*Everyone deserves equal justice.*
victim	n	a person harmed by a crime	*The victim received support from the police.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
workforce	n	all the people who work in a place
unemployment	n	having no job
career ladder	n	the path of promotion in a job
work-life balance	n	the balance between job and personal life
salary	n	regular pay for a job
promotion	n	a move to a better job
remote work	n	working away from the office
job security	n	the likelihood of keeping your job
entrepreneur	n	a person who starts a business
colleague	n	a person you work with

Practice: fill the gaps

prison overcrowding · witness · fine · vandalism · burglary · sentence · surveillance camera · community service

1. _____ makes rehabilitation harder.
2. The _____ described the thief.
3. The company paid a heavy _____.
4. _____ spoils public parks.
5. _____ rates fell last year.
6. He received a five-year _____.
7. _____ reduced street crime.
8. _____ helps the offender give back.

More words on this topic **(not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)**

arrest (v): to take someone to the police
bail (n): money paid to be free before a trial
blackmail (n): threatening to reveal secrets for money
bribe (n): money given to get an unfair favor
crime rate (n): how often crimes happen
criminal record (n): a list of someone's past offenses
cybercrime (n): crime committed online
detective (n): a police officer who investigates crimes
drug trafficking (n): the illegal trade in drugs
evidence (n): facts that show something is true
forensic (adj): using science to solve crimes
gang (n): a group of criminals
harsh (adj): severe
imprisonment (n): being put in prison
jury (n): a group of citizens who decide a verdict
life sentence (n): a punishment of prison for life
mugging (n): a violent street robbery
murder (n): killing a person on purpose
parole (n): early release for good behavior
petty crime (n): minor crime
police force (n): the police as a body
probation (n): supervision instead of prison
robbery (n): stealing by force
shoplifting (n): stealing from shops
suspect (n): a person thought to be guilty
theft (n): stealing
trial (n): a legal process in a court
violent crime (n): crime that harms people
verdict (n): the decision of a court
zero tolerance (n): no excuses for rule-breaking

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people think prison is the best way to reduce crime; others prefer education and rehabilitation. Discuss both views.
2. Crime among young people is rising. What are the causes and what solutions can you suggest?
3. Some think the death penalty should be allowed for serious crimes. To what extent do you agree?
4. Surveillance cameras in public places help to reduce crime. Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Harsh penalties may deter crime and protect the public by removing dangerous people.
- **Against / bad:** Prison often turns petty offenders into hardened criminals, so reoffending stays high.
- **For / good:** Education and job training give offenders a real chance of a normal life.
- **Against / bad:** Rehabilitation programs are costly and may seem too soft on victims.
- **For / good:** Cameras help police catch offenders and make people feel safer.
- **Against / bad:** Constant surveillance reduces privacy and can be misused by the state.

Speaking

Part 1

- Is your area safe?
- Do you lock your door at night?
- Have you ever seen a crime?
- Do you watch crime films?
- Do you feel safe on public transport?

Part 3

- Why do people commit crimes?
- Should young offenders be treated differently?
- Is prison an effective punishment?
- What can communities do to reduce crime?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a time you helped someone. You should say: who you helped, what the problem was, how you helped, and explain how you felt.

Answers

1. Prison overcrowding (prison overcrowding)
2. witness (witness)
3. fine (fine)
4. Vandalism (vandalism)
5. Burglary (burglary)
6. sentence (sentence)
7. Surveillance cameras (surveillance camera)
8. Community service (community service)